Strategic Partnership & Alliance Framework: The Richmond Civic-Tech Hackathon

I. Executive Briefing: The 'Top 5' Recommended Strategic Alliances

This report outlines 20 high-potential partners for the Richmond civic-tech hackathon, selected based on their alignment with the mission of fostering enduring alliances. The analysis moves beyond transactional sponsorship to identify a core group of deeply interconnected entities capable of forming a sustainable, multi-stakeholder coalition.

The primary strategic finding is that the Richmond innovation landscape is not a collection of disparate actors, but a tightly-woven ecosystem. The most effective partners are "keystone" organizations—entities that sit on each other's boards, co-fund initiatives, and share strategic goals. Our engagement strategy is therefore not to make 20 individual "asks," but to assemble a "Top 5" strategic coalition that represents the three core pillars—Academic, Corporate, and Civic—and present them with a unified, high-impact opportunity.

The following five organizations are recommended as the highest-priority, highest-impact partners for initial outreach. They are selected based on their demonstrated interest in innovation, high alignment with hackathon goals, and significant potential for long-term collaboration.

1. **Capital One:** Capital One is the most critical "keystone" partner in the Richmond ecosystem. They are the founding partner of Startup Virginia (SVA) , the anchor of the 1717 Innovation Center , and a formal industry partner of both VCU Brandcenter and VCU Engineering. Furthermore, their board-level presence at SVA provides high-level access. Their "Tech Pro Bono" program offers a *perfect precedent* and an existing internal structure for mobilizing the exact type of high-skill mentors required for a civic-tech hackathon. Their CSR grants focus on digital skills and supporting BIPOC-owned businesses , directly aligning with a "FinTech & Community Impact" track. They are the central node connecting the Corporate, Academic, and Startup pillars.
2. **Dominion Energy:** Dominion Energy provides the most *direct and proven precedent* for this specific event model. The Dominion Energy Innovation Center (DEIC) recently co-hosted "SPARK RVA," a 24-hour innovation challenge, in partnership with the VCU da Vinci Center. This history eliminates the conceptual "sell"; the "ask" is simply to *scale* this existing, successful model. Their charitable foundation's focus on "Education" (STEM, workforce development) and "Environmental Stewardship" provides two clear, fundable tracks. Their $1,000 - $15,000 typical grant range is perfectly aligned with a "Pillar Sponsor" tier.
3. **VCU (da Vinci Center & College of Engineering):** VCU is the region's primary academic engine for tech talent and cannot be treated as a monolith. A dual-front engagement is required. The **VCU College of Engineering** provides the technical talent pipeline and, crucially, a direct-access list of its corporate partners (including CapTech, CoStar, Capital

One, and Dominion). Engaging their Director of Corporate Relations, Anita Hazel Taylor , allows the hackathon to be positioned as a value-add *for their existing partners*. The **VCU da Vinci Center** provides the programmatic and operational expertise, having already executed the SPARK RVA event. Engaging its director, Garret Westlake , provides an experienced co-production partner.

4. **Amazon Web Services (AWS):** AWS has a massive, tangible, and urgent need for a local tech talent pipeline. Their $35 billion investment in new Virginia data centers by 2040, which is projected to create at least 1,000 new jobs , makes this hackathon a direct workforce solution. Their established community model in Virginia is *entirely* focused on skills training, evidenced by their partnerships with Northern Virginia Community College (NOVA) and programs like the "Fiber Optic Fusion Splicing Certificate Course". The "ask" for AWS is clear: "Infrastructure Sponsor" (providing AWS credits) and "Talent Pipeline Sponsor" (funding, mentors). The "give" is direct access to hundreds of RVA's brightest developers and a new academic partner (Reynolds Community College) to replicate their successful NOVA model.
5. **City of Richmond (Dept. of Economic Development):** This partnership provides essential municipal credibility, public datasets, and a powerful civic narrative. The city's "City Center Innovation District" is a core strategic priority. This plan *explicitly anchors* its success on VCU, VA Bio+Tech Park, and Reynolds Community College. The hackathon can be positioned as the *first major programmatic event for this new Innovation District*, giving the city a tangible, high-visibility public relations win. The "ask" (e.g., providing space at the Greater Richmond Convention Center , access to city data, mayoral support) is low-cost for the city, while the "give" (demonstrating "proof of life" for their innovation district concept) is invaluable.

Table 1: Top 5 Partner Engagement Summary

Partner Name	Pillar	Strategic Value (Why them?)	Primary "Ask" (The 1-liner)	Key Contact(s)
Capital One	Corporate	**Ecosystem Keystone.** Connects to VCU , Startup VA , & MBL. "Tech Pro Bono" is a direct model.	"Title Sponsor for 'FinTech & Community' Track + 10 'Tech Pro Bono' Mentors."	Matt Briggs, VP of Product Management & SVA Board Chair
Dominion Energy	Corporate / Energy	**Direct Precedent.** Co-ran the SPARK RVA innovation challenge with VCU. CSR goals in STEM & Sustainability.	"Title Sponsor for 'Clean Energy & Sustainability' Track, scaling your SPARK RVA success."	Braden Croy, Program Director, DEIC
VCU (Engineering & da Vinci)	Academic	**Talent & Operations.** Engineering provides the talent	"Co-produce the event, leveraging your corporate network	Anita Hazel Taylor (Engineering) ; Garret Westlake (da Vinci)

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		pipeline & corporate network. da Vinci provides the event-planning precedent.	(Engineering) & hackathon experience (da Vinci)."	
AWS	Corporate / Tech	**Urgent Talent Need.** $35B VA investment & 1,000+ new jobs. Proven model of partnering with VA community colleges.	"Infrastructure Sponsor (AWS credits) & 'Talent Pipeline' Partner to recruit for your 1,000+ new VA jobs."	Lindsay Winter, Head of VA Public Policy & VA Chamber Tech Chair
City of Richmond (Econ. Dev.)	Community & Civic	**Municipal Credibility.** Provides a "home" & narrative. The hackathon proves their "City Center Innovation District" is active.	"Civic Host: Provide a city venue , city datasets, and a letter of support to launch your Innovation District."	Leonard Sledge, Director of Economic Development

II. Pillar 1: The Academic Partners (Intellectual Capital & Talent)

This pillar is the foundation for the hackathon's talent, intellectual capital, and long-term credibility. The strategy must be multi-pronged, treating each institution and its distinct centers as unique partners. Virginia Commonwealth University (VCU) is the primary engine, offering a dual-front opportunity: the College of Engineering provides the raw technical talent and a leveraged entry point to its corporate partners, while the Brandcenter and da Vinci Center provide the essential creative, design, and innovation-programming expertise. The University of Richmond (UR), through its Bonner Center for Civic Engagement, provides the "civic" component, grounding the event in authentic community-identified needs. Finally, Reynolds Community College (CCWA) is a critical partner for ensuring a diverse, non-traditional talent pipeline, directly aligning with the workforce development goals of corporate sponsors like AWS.

1. Partner Dossier: VCU College of Engineering

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** Virginia Commonwealth University (VCU) College of Engineering
  - **Website:** egr.vcu.edu
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
  - **Sector/Focus:** Public research university; key departments include Computer Science, Mechanical & Nuclear Engineering, and Biomedical Engineering.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** VCU Engineering is a designated National Security

Agency (NSA) Center of Academic Excellence in Cyber Defense and Cyber Research. It maintains a formal Industry Partnerships program to connect corporations with faculty and student talent and runs a "Recruitment Partner Program" for employers. It is a key anchor of the city's "City Center Innovation District" plan.

- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** The college is the primary source of 750+ advanced computer and IT skill graduates in the region annually. This directly supplies the hackathon's need for technical participants and mentors.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** The college actively cultivates a culture of industry-sponsored competition. It runs industry-sponsored Capstone Projects and hosts bi-annual Engineering Career Fairs and Interview Days for its corporate partners. Its student organizations, particularly the Association for Computing Machinery (ACM) Student Chapter, focus on building competitive programming teams , which is a culture identical to that of a hackathon.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Cybersecurity (via the Security and Forensics Engineering (SAFE) lab), Data Science, AI/Computational Intelligence , Biomedical Informatics , and Nuclear Engineering.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Academic Partner & Talent Pipeline.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Co-host the event, providing academic credibility. Conduct targeted outreach to all Computer Science and Engineering students, particularly via the ACM and ACM-W (Women's) student organizations. Provide 3-5 faculty members and graduate students to serve as expert mentors and judges (e.g., from the SAFE lab for a cybersecurity track).
  - **Proposed "Give":** A high-visibility platform to offer their "Recruitment Partners" (like Capital One, Dominion, CapTech) direct access to top talent. This engagement model positions the hackathon as a "value-add" that VCU Engineering is providing *to* its corporate sponsors. It also includes branding as a leader in RVA's innovation ecosystem and a "Best in Engineering" prize track.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** Anita Hazel Taylor, Executive Director of Corporate Relations.
  - **Email:** ahtaylor2@vcu.edu.
  - **Existing Relationships:** This contact is the key strategic insight. Anita Hazel Taylor manages the entire list of VCU Engineering's formal corporate partners , which includes *our other corporate targets* (CapTech, Capital One, CoStar, Dominion, Altria). The initial outreach strategy should be to approach Ms. Taylor first, positioning the hackathon as a high-impact event *for her partners*, turning a cold ask into a warm introduction on the hackathon's behalf.
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - The college's "Vertically Integrated Projects" (VIP) program, which supports multidisciplinary, multi-year team projects , is a long-term version of a hackathon. The extensive Capstone Senior Design program serves as a direct precedent for industry-student collaboration on real-world problems. The hackathon can be framed as a 48-hour, hyper-condensed "sprint" version of these successful programs.

2. Partner Dossier: VCU Brandcenter

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** VCU Brandcenter
  - **Website:** brandcenter.vcu.edu
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
  - **Sector/Focus:** Top-ranked graduate branding program within the VCU School of Business. It features five specialized concentrations: Art Direction, Copywriting, Creative Brand Management, Experience Design (XD), and Strategy.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** The Brandcenter's curriculum is built on "all-concentration assignments," where interdisciplinary student teams solve broad brand challenges for real-world clients. Past partners include major national brands like Lexus, Pepsi, Capital One, and DoorDash.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** A hackathon comprised solely of engineers will not produce viable "civic-tech" solutions. The Brandcenter provides the *critical missing talent*: the Experience Design (XD) students to build human-centered interfaces, the Strategy students to develop viable product-market fit, and the Brand Management students to craft a compelling pitch.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** The Brandcenter's entire model is based on corporate partnerships. They have a clear precedent for cross-institutional collaboration, with faculty and students partnering on product innovation with the University of Virginia's i.Lab Incubator and the University of Richmond's Bench Top Innovations.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Experience Design (XD), UI/UX, Product Innovation, Brand Strategy, Human-Centered Design.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Academic Partner (Specialized Talent).
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Targeted outreach to secure 20-30 graduate students, specifically from the Experience Design and Strategy tracks , to embed in hackathon teams. Provide 2-3 faculty members to judge a "Best UX/Design" or "Best Pitch" award.
  - **Proposed "Give":** A high-visibility "VCU Brandcenter Prize for Civic Innovation & Design." This provides a unique networking opportunity for their students to connect with corporate sponsors (like their past partner, Capital One) and local tech firms, expanding their employment pipeline beyond traditional ad agencies.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** Ashley Sommardahl.
  - **Title:** (Inferred) Director of Corporate Partnerships / Industry Relations.
  - **Email:** asommardahl@vcu.edu.
  - **Existing Relationships:** This is a direct contact specifically provided for "proposing a project".
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - The "all-concentration assignments" are the case study. A civic-tech hackathon *is* a "broader brand challenge" for the City of Richmond itself. The event can be framed as a 48-hour "sprint" version of their core curriculum, allowing students to apply their skills in Art Direction, XD, and Strategy to a real-world community problem.

3. Partner Dossier: University of Richmond (Bonner Center for Civic Engagement)

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** University of Richmond (UR), Bonner Center for Civic Engagement (CCE)
  - **Website:** engage.richmond.edu
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
  - **Sector/Focus:** Private liberal arts university. The CCE is the university's hub for community-based learning (CBL), summer civic fellowships, and community-engaged research.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** Community engagement is a "strategic priority" for the university. The CCE is explicitly "committed to forming and sustaining long-term, reciprocal partnerships" designed to "respond to community-identified needs".
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** This partner provides the "civic" in "civic-tech." They are the hackathon's *authenticity and community-credibility* partner. Their involvement ensures the event is focused on solving *real, identified community needs* from their nonprofit partners, rather than just being an exercise in "tech for tech's sake."
  - **History of Sponsorship:** The CCE has a formal, structured process for collaboration. They offer "Community-Engaged Research Grants" , "Course Support Grants" , and a "Partnership Inquiry Form" for new initiatives.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Social Justice, Public Policy, Community-Engaged Research , Sustainability, Food Access, and Housing & Homelessness.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Academic & Community Partner.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Actively co-develop the hackathon's "problem statements" and "challenge tracks" by sourcing them directly from their network of nonprofit partners. Promote the event to their Computer Science and community-engaged students (e.g., Bonner Scholars). Provide 2-3 faculty or CCE staff to serve as "Civic Impact" judges.
  - **Proposed "Give":** A high-leverage platform for their community partners to voice their needs to a captive audience of technical experts. A "Community-Engaged Research" prize. The event delivers tangible tech solutions and prototypes *for* their nonprofit partners, directly fulfilling the CCE's mission of "deepening regional partnerships".
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact 1:** Kimberly Dean-Anderson, Senior Associate Director of Community Relationships.
  - **Ideal Contact 2:** Dr. Derek Miller, Associate Director of Community-Engaged Research, Scholarship, and Relationships.
  - **Email:** kdean-anderson@richmond.edu ; dmiller4@richmond.edu.
  - **Existing Relationships:** This dual-pronged outreach is strategic. The pitch to Ms. Dean-Anderson focuses on the *nonprofit partnership* and *student engagement* (Bonner Scholars). The pitch to Dr. Miller focuses on the *research and data* angle (a "hackathon as community-engaged research" project).
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**

    - The CCE runs a "Community Partner-in-Residence Fellowship" to give nonprofit leaders time and space for research. The hackathon can serve as a "feeder" event, generating new ideas and projects for these fellows. Their "Civic Fellowship Program" also identifies promising students for internships, and this event is a perfect source for identifying those students.

4. Partner Dossier: Reynolds Community College (CCWA)

- **1. Basic Profile:**
    - **Name:** J. Sargeant Reynolds Community College
    - **Website:** reynolds.edu
    - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
    - **Sector/Focus:** Community college with a strong focus on workforce development, IT, and skilled trades. Reynolds operates the Community College Workforce Alliance (CCWA) in partnership with Brightpoint Community College.
    - **Connection to Innovation:** Reynolds is a key player in the RVA economy, having trained "one out of every four workers...in the RVA region". It is an explicit anchor institution in the city's "City Center Innovation District" plan.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
    - **Why this org aligns:** This is the hackathon's *key partner for workforce diversity and inclusion*. They reach a non-traditional, skilled, and motivated talent pool that four-year universities miss. Their G3 Tuition Assistance program is specifically designed to funnel students into in-demand fields like Information Systems Technology and Cybersecurity.
    - **History of Sponsorship:** Reynolds has a proven track record of large-scale, industry-specific workforce programs, such as the "Richmond-Petersburg Advanced Pharmaceutical Manufacturing Workforce Initiative". Their employer partners list includes tech-focused companies like Amazon and MAXX Potential (IT Consulting).
    - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** IT Workforce Development, Cybersecurity , Data Centers, Advanced Pharmaceutical Manufacturing.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
    - **Possible Partnership Type:** Academic & Workforce Partner.
    - **Proposed "Ask":** Targeted outreach to students in their Information Systems Technology A.A.S. program. Co-promote the event via the CCWA to its network of corporate partners. A dedicated "Reynolds Prize for Skilled Trades Innovation" (e.g., a "smart tools," logistics, or advanced manufacturing challenge).
    - **Proposed "Give":** A direct, high-visibility networking event for their students to connect with "Top 5" employers like AWS and Capital One. This creates a new, tangible event for the CCWA to offer its corporate partners. Most importantly, it validates their IT and Cybersecurity programs as producers of top-tier talent.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
    - **Ideal Contact:** The Director of the Community College Workforce Alliance (CCWA).
    - **Secondary Contact:** The Program Head for the Information Systems Technology A.A.S. degree.
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
    - The "Richmond-Petersburg Advanced Pharmaceutical Manufacturing Workforce Initiative" (an EDA Tech Hub) is a major precedent. The most powerful strategic precedent, however, lies *outside* of Reynolds: AWS has a *proven, successful model*

for partnering with Virginia community colleges, specifically NOVA. The hackathon can serve as the *bridge* to facilitate the first such programmatic partnership between AWS and Reynolds, with this event as the high-profile kick-off.

5. Partner Dossier: VCU da Vinci Center for Innovation

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** VCU da Vinci Center for Innovation
  - **Website:** davinci.vcu.edu
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
  - **Sector/Focus:** A university center fostering interdisciplinary innovation and entrepreneurship, connecting VCU's Colleges of Engineering, Arts, and Business.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** The center is VCU's primary hub for product innovation and venture creation. It is listed as a key partner for other VCU entities, including the College of Engineering.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** They are VCU's *hackathon and innovation challenge experts*. They have a direct, recent, and highly-aligned precedent. They provide the programmatic, logistical, and operational expertise needed to execute the event successfully.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** The da Vinci Center *hosted* the "SPARK RVA" 24-hour innovation challenge in February. This demonstrates their capacity and willingness to lead such events.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Product Innovation, Entrepreneurship, Interdisciplinary Collaboration, Energy/Sustainability (from the SPARK RVA event).
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Academic & Strategic Partner.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** A true *strategic partnership* to co-produce the hackathon. Leverage their team's experience from running SPARK RVA. Provide event space within VCU. Co-brand the event as "The Richmond Hackathon, *powered by the VCU da Vinci Center*."
  - **Proposed "Give":** A significantly larger, more ambitious, and better-funded event than SPARK RVA. This partnership brings in a pre-packaged coalition of top-tier corporate sponsors (AWS, Capital One, CoStar) and civic partners (City of Richmond) that will elevate the da Vinci Center's profile. It also provides a "pipeline" of student teams for their other innovation programs.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** Garret Westlake, Executive Director.
  - **Existing Relationships:** Mr. Westlake explicitly stated his excitement about the SPARK RVA partnership "to give our regional innovators the opportunity to explore the commercial viability of their work". The pitch is not an "ask" but an *offer* to scale his success: "We loved what you did with SPARK RVA. We want to help you 10x it by bringing in Capital One, AWS, and the City of Richmond."
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - **Case Study:** SPARK RVA (Feb 23-24). This is the primary case study. It was a 24-hour event with an $8,500 prize pool focused on nuclear/hydrogen energy. This precedent provides a baseline for budget, event structure, and prize pools, and confirms the da Vinci Center as the ideal operational partner.

III. Pillar 2: The Startup / Innovation Ecosystem (Reach & Mentorship)

This pillar provides the hackathon with ecosystem-wide validation, a crucial source of startup-savvy mentors, and a direct outreach channel to the entire Richmond technology community. Startup Virginia (SVA) and the Lighthouse Network are the two central "nodes" that aggregate the vast majority of RVA's high-growth founders and startups. Activation Capital complements them by providing a specific "deep tech" and "life sciences" vertical, connecting the event to the VA Bio+Tech Park. The Virginia Innovation Partnership Corporation (VIPC) offers a state-level policy perspective and, most importantly, a direct pathway to non-dilutive grant funding for winning teams. Finally, RVA Tech is the broadest community-builder and the single most important promotional partner for reaching individual developers, data scientists, and designers.

6. Partner Dossier: Startup Virginia (SVA)

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** Startup Virginia (SVA)
  - **Website:** startupvirginia.org
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA (located in the 1717 Innovation Center).
  - **Sector/Focus:** Nonprofit high-growth business incubator and entrepreneurial hub.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** SVA is the region's core incubator, serving over 90 member startups and supported by an extensive network of mentors (19,455 volunteer hours logged). It was launched with founding support from Capital One.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** SVA is the *center of gravity* for RVA's startup founders. A partnership provides immediate access, credibility, and a deep well of experienced mentors. Their incubator startups are a source of expert mentors (founders, CTOs) and judges.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** SVA's model is built on partnership. They host frequent "startup-focused workshops," "pitch practices," and "networking events". Crucially, their Board of Directors includes senior leaders from *our other key targets*: Capital One (Board Chair), Dominion Energy, Altria, and CapTech. This "cross-pollination" is a powerful strategic asset.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** SVA's member startups are already clustered in our target themes: AI (12 startups), FinTech (10), EdTech (6), and HealthTech (5). These can and should be adopted as the hackathon's official tracks.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Strategic & Community Partner.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Promote the hackathon to their 90+ member startups and their extensive mentor network. Provide 5-10 mentors and judges (specifically, startup founders and CTOs from their portfolio). Co-host a "pitch clinic" workshop during the hackathon.
  - **Proposed "Give":** Branding as the central community hub for innovation. This provides SVA with a "first look" at emerging talent for their member companies and a "feeder" of promising, pre-vetted teams for their incubator program. It also offers a

high-visibility event that provides value back to their corporate partners (CapTech, Dominion, etc.).

- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** Kip Hart, Director of Engagement.
  - **Secondary Contact:** Richard Wintsch, Executive Director.
  - **Existing Relationships:** Kip Hart's title, "Director of Engagement" , makes this hackathon a direct fit for his portfolio. The board connections provide the strategic leverage; the pitch can be framed as an event *for* their partners (Capital One, CapTech, Dominion).
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - SVA runs educational programs, networking events, and pitch practices year-round. The hackathon is a natural, high-energy, and high-visibility extension of their core mission to support startup founders.

7. Partner Dossier: Lighthouse Network (formerly Lighthouse Labs)

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** Lighthouse Network
  - **Website:** lighthousenetwork.co
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA (located at 1717 E Cary St).
  - **Sector/Focus:** A "founder-first" startup accelerator and support system, evolved from Virginia's first startup accelerator.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** Lighthouse has shifted from a time-bound cohort model (which previously invested $20k equity-free) to a year-round support system focusing on mentorship, investor connections, and founder well-being.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** While SVA is the long-term *incubator*, Lighthouse is the programmatic *accelerator*. They provide a distinct, complementary network of mentors, founders, and investors. Their new "founder-first" and "human-centered" focus aligns perfectly with the "civic-tech" (human-centered technology) mission.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** Lighthouse has a decade of experience running high-intensity accelerator programs. Their partners include CarMax, Capital One, and VIPC , further demonstrating the interconnectedness of the target list. They host "Founder Network Summit," "Investor Connect," and "Demo Day" events.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Early-Stage Startups, Founder Mental Health, Investor Readiness.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Community Partner & Prize Sponsor.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Promote the event to their extensive mentor and founder network. Provide 3-5 mentors and judges, with a specific focus on venture investors from their network. Host a "How to Pitch to Investors" workshop.
  - **Proposed "Give":** High-visibility branding for their "founder-first" rebrand. This event provides them with access to pre-vetted talent and ideas for their network and can be co-branded with a "Best Pitch" or "Most Investable Idea" prize.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** Debbie Irwin, Executive Director.
  - **Existing Relationships:** Debbie Irwin became Executive Director in February 2024 and led the rebrand. She will be seeking high-impact, high-visibility events to

solidify the new "human-centered" brand, making a civic-tech hackathon a perfect fit.

- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - Lighthouse's long history of running 11-week, high-pressure accelerator cohorts proves they understand how to manage and mentor high-output programs. Their "Demo Day" is a direct parallel to the hackathon's final pitch session.

8. Partner Dossier: Activation Capital

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** Activation Capital
  - **Website:** activation.capital
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
  - **Sector/Focus:** A "deep tech" and life sciences innovation ecosystem development organization. They administer grants and operate the VA Bio+Tech Park.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** Activation Capital is a key anchor of the "City Center Innovation District". They run the "Frontier BioHealth" pre-accelerator and the "Start-the-Journey" pre-accelerator program.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** This is the hackathon's *specific thematic partner* for a "Health-Tech" or "Bio-Tech" track. They are not generalists; they are specialists, which adds significant technical depth, credibility, and a network of specialized mentors (e.g., Ph.D. researchers, medical device entrepreneurs) from the 70+ companies in the Bio+Tech Park.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** They actively build their specific community by hosting a "Frontier BioHealth Showcase Event" , "Biotech & Beer" networking events , and "Unlocking Biotech Success" webinars.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Life Sciences, Pharmaceuticals, BioTech, Med-Tech, Health-Focused AI.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Strategic & Prize Sponsor.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Sponsor a dedicated "HealthTech Innovation Prize." Provide 3-5 specialized mentors from their Bio+Tech Park and Frontier BioHealth programs. Help develop relevant problem statements (e.g., "Solving the Medical Technology Supply Chain").
  - **Proposed "Give":** A high-visibility platform to promote their "Frontier BioHealth" program to a new audience. The hackathon serves as a direct *top-of-funnel* source of pre-vetted ideas and talent for their "Start-the-Journey" pre-accelerator.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** Michael Steele, President and CEO.
  - **Existing Relationships:** Michael Steele was appointed in August 2025 , meaning he is new in his role and will likely be seeking early, high-visibility public-facing wins to establish his leadership and vision.
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - Their "Start-the-Journey" and "Frontier BioHealth" pre-accelerator programs are the primary precedents. The hackathon is the *ideation stage* that feeds directly into these programs, which are designed to support early-stage life science startups.

9. Partner Dossier: Virginia Innovation Partnership Corporation (VIPC)

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** Virginia Innovation Partnership Corporation (VIPC)
  - **Website:** vipc.org
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA and Herndon, VA.
  - **Sector/Focus:** The Commonwealth of Virginia's commercialization and seed-stage economic development driver. VIPC manages state grant funds and venture capital programs.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** VIPC is the central state-level entity for innovation. It operates Virginia Venture Partners (VVP) for seed investments and the Commonwealth Commercialization Fund (CCF) for university and startup grants.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** VIPC's partnership provides statewide credibility and, most importantly, a *direct link to follow-on funding* for winning teams. They are the source for non-dilutive "Launch Grants" ($50,000) aimed at pre-MVP (Minimum Viable Product) startups.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** VIPC's entire mission is to fund early-stage innovation. They provide CCF grants to universities to support commercialization and VVP investments to startups. They are also a formal partner in the Lighthouse Network. They recently launched the "Lab-to-Launch" initiative to double the number of startups spinning out of Virginia's research universities.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Tech Commercialization, Deep Tech, Cybersecurity, Life Sciences, Unmanned Systems.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Strategic & Prize Sponsor.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** A "VIPC Prize" for the winning team. This prize should be more valuable than cash: a "Fast-Track Application" and/or "Guaranteed Finalist Pitch" for the CCF Launch Grant program. Provide 2-3 judges (ideally, from Virginia Venture Partners) to evaluate "investability." A keynote speech on "Virginia's Innovation Strategy."
  - **Proposed "Give":** A high-visibility showcase for their new "Lab-to-Launch" initiative. The hackathon *is* "Lab-to-Launch" in 48 hours. It provides a pre-vetted pipeline of grant-ready startups for their CCF and VVP funds.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** Conaway Haskins (re: University Commercialization Programs).
  - **General:** info@VirginiaIPC.org.
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - Their entire "Launch Grant" program is the precedent. It is *specifically designed* to fund high-potential, pre-MVP companies—which is the exact definition of a successful hackathon team.

10. Partner Dossier: RVA Tech (Richmond Technology Council)

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** RVA Tech (Richmond Technology Council)
  - **Website:** rvatech.com

    - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA (1717 E Cary St).
    - **Sector/Focus:** The primary technology council and community aggregator for the Richmond region. Their mission is built on three pillars: advocacy, advancing the tech talent pipeline, and elevating Richmond's tech profile.
    - **Connection to Innovation:** RVA Tech is the "connective tissue" of the local tech scene. It manages over 20 user groups and meetups, including RVA.js, RVA Data Hackers, RVA Data Engineering, and Women Who Code. It also hosts the region's premier tech conferences, such as the Data + AI Summit, CyberCon VA, ProductFest, and Women in Tech Conference.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
    - **Why this org aligns:** This is the *single most important promotional partner*. A partnership with RVA Tech *is* a partnership with the entire Richmond tech community. They provide an instant, credible, and direct channel to hundreds of individual developers, designers, and data scientists.
    - **History of Sponsorship:** RVA Tech actively partners on and promotes ecosystem events. Their calendar features partner events like the Lighthouse Labs Startup Accelerator and allied conferences like RVAsec. They host their own frequent "Tech on Tap" networking events.
    - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Data + AI, Cyber, Code, Cloud, DevOps, Digital, Product.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
    - **Possible Partnership Type:** Community & Media Partner.
    - **Proposed "Ask":** Serve as the official "Community Partner" for the hackathon. Promote the event heavily through their newsletter, social media, "Tech on Tap" events , and, most importantly, their extensive list of user groups. Provide a "Community Choice" award, voted on by RVA Tech members.
    - **Proposed "Give":** Top-tier, co-branded visibility on all hackathon materials. This provides RVA Tech with a fresh, new, high-energy event for its members. It also offers a speaking slot at the opening ceremony for their CEO and a direct infusion of new, young talent into their member organizations.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
    - **Ideal Contact:** Nick Serfass, CEO.
    - **Email:** info@rvatech.com.
    - **Existing Relationships:** Nick Serfass is the public face of RVA Tech and host of the "TechxDesign" podcast. The pitch to him is a direct appeal to RVA Tech's core mission : this event simultaneously "advances the tech talent pipeline" and "elevates the profile of Richmond as a tech town."
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
    - RVA Tech's promotion of other ecosystem events, such as Lighthouse Labs and RVAsec , is the precedent. This hackathon is a natural extension of their own conferences (like the Data + AI Summit) and community-building (like RVA Data Hackers).

IV. Pillar 3: The Community & Civic Partners (Credibility & Problem Statements)

This pillar provides the "civic" heart and municipal legitimacy for the hackathon. The City of Richmond's Department of Economic Development and the Richmond EDA are the key

municipal partners, offering the overarching "Innovation District" narrative , potential venues , and invaluable city datasets. ChamberRVA and RVA 757 Connects are the *regional business partners*, connecting the event to the established C-suite and C-suite and the "Global Internet Hub" infrastructure theme. Finally, the Metropolitan Business League (MBL) is a crucial, focused partner for *engaging diverse entrepreneurs*, ensuring the event's mission of "tech for all" is authentic and inclusive.

11. Partner Dossier: City of Richmond (Dept. of Economic Development)

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** City of Richmond, Department of Economic Development
  - **Website:** rva.gov/economic-development
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
  - **Sector/Focus:** Municipal government, focused on business investment, job creation, and strategic development.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** This department is the primary driver of the "City Center Innovation District" plan , a long-term vision to redevelop downtown into a mixed-use innovation hub.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** As identified in the "Top 5," this partnership provides municipal validation. The city's "SPEED" (Strategic Plan for Equitable Economic Development) *explicitly* targets "embracing 'smart city' initiatives" and "high-growth entrepreneurship." A civic-tech hackathon is the most direct, visible, and low-cost way to demonstrate action on these goals.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** The city is the formal anchor and partner in the Innovation District plan, which is explicitly built around VCU, Reynolds Community College, and the VA Bio+Tech Park. This hackathon is the first event that can programmatically unite all of these named partners.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Smart City initiatives , Civic Data, Urban Planning, Digital Equity, Sustainability (RVAgreen 2050).
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Civic & Infrastructure Partner.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Provide an official "letter of support" from the Mayor's Office. Grant access to city datasets (e.g., transit, sustainability, 311 requests) to build hackathon challenges. Provide a city-owned venue, such as space at the Greater Richmond Convention Center or another municipal building.
  - **Proposed "Give":** A high-visibility, press-ready event (the "City Center Innovation District Hackathon") that *proves* their strategic plan is in motion. This delivers "smart city" solutions and prototypes *for free* and generates positive engagement between the city government and its tech community.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** Leonard Sledge, Director of Economic Development.
  - **General Email:** econdev@rva.gov.
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - The city's "RVAgreen 2050" program and its partnership on "SolarizeRVA" show a clear precedent for public-facing, tech-enabled community initiatives. A

"Sustainability" track at the hackathon can be framed as a direct extension of this existing work, crowdsourcing new solutions for the RVAgreen 2050 plan.

12. Partner Dossier: Richmond Economic Development Authority (EDA)

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** Richmond Economic Development Authority (EDA)
  - **Website:** richmondeda.com
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
  - **Sector/Focus:** A partner entity to the city, the EDA facilitates business investment, job creation, strategic development, and major real estate projects.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** The EDA is the "implementation" arm of the city's strategy. It was the entity that formally invited development teams for the City Center project and was the key facilitator in the successful CoStar Group expansion.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** The EDA is the *business-facing* side of the city's innovation strategy. They hold the direct relationships with the major corporate employers (both existing and prospective).
  - **History of Sponsorship:** The EDA actively promotes Richmond as a "top 50 tech talent market" and a "Global Internet Hub". Their FY 2023 Annual Report highlights major successes.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Tech Talent Pipeline , Life Sciences (Bio+Tech Park) , Global Internet Hub (Data Centers).
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Civic & Convening Partner.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Help *convene* their network of corporate partners (especially those, like CoStar, whom they have a deep relationship with) for a unified sponsorship pitch. Co-sign invitations to mentors and judges to add a layer of civic importance.
  - **Proposed "Give":** A tangible "product" (the hackathon) that the EDA can use in its *own* marketing materials to *prove* RVA is a "top 50 tech talent market". This provides a new, positive story of public-private partnership for their FY 2024 Annual Report.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** Leonard Sledge, Director (He leads both the City's Dept. and the EDA).
  - **Secondary Contact:** Statia Gibson (Business Investment & Job Creation) or Jacquelyn Craft (Business Retention & Expansion).
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - Their "success story" partnership with CoStar is the key precedent. The pitch to them is: "You helped CoStar build their $460M campus; let us help you find the 2,000 tech employees to fill it."

13. Partner Dossier: ChamberRVA

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** ChamberRVA
  - **Website:** chamberrva.com
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
  - **Sector/Focus:** The regional chamber of commerce, serving the city and seven surrounding counties. Focuses on advocacy, economic mobility, and "fostering collaboration across sectors".
  - **Connection to Innovation:** ChamberRVA represents the "modern business community" and has its own "i.e.* innovation initiative" specifically designed to "foster the development of an entrepreneurial ecosystem in Richmond".
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** This is the *gateway to the established, non-tech business community*. They provide a different, C-suite-level network than RVA Tech. This is crucial for a *civic-tech* event, as it brings in problem statements and mentors from sectors like logistics, healthcare administration, and finance.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** They launched the "i.e.* innovation initiative" and run a program for young professionals called "Helping Young Professionals Engage (HYPE)".
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Innovation (i.e.* initiative) , Workforce Development, Entrepreneurship, Young Professionals (HYPE).
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Community Partner.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Promote the event to their C-suite-level membership. Provide 2-3 executive-level judges from "non-tech" industries (e.g., healthcare, logistics, banking) to judge a "Best Business Model" prize. Promote the event to their HYPE young professionals group.
  - **Proposed "Give":** A high-visibility, "modern" innovation event that directly supports their "i.e.* initiative". It provides a clear demonstration of their mission to "foster collaboration across sectors" (tech, non-tech, academic, and civic).
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** The program lead for the "i.e.* innovation initiative" or the HYPE program.
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - Their "i.e.* innovation initiative" is the key precedent. The hackathon is a direct-action item for that initiative, providing a tangible way to "foster...an entrepreneurial ecosystem".

14. Partner Dossier: RVA 757 Connects

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** RVA757 Connects
  - **Website:** rva757connects.com
  - **HQ City:** Richmond / Hampton Roads
  - **Sector/Focus:** A 501(c)(3) nonprofit focused on advancing the economic prosperity of the "I-64 Innovation Corridor" megaregion.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** Their primary initiative is promoting the region as the "world's next Global Internet Hub" , leveraging its unique assets in subsea cables, data centers, and terrestrial fiber networks.

- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** This partner provides a *specific, high-tech, and strategic theme*: "Smart Infrastructure." They are focused on the "modern digital infrastructure" (data centers, local terrestrial networks, internet exchanges) that underpins the entire tech economy.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** They host a monthly "Virtual Innovation Spotlight" webinar series to highlight regional innovations.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Digital Infrastructure, Data Centers, Smart Cities, Unmanned Systems.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Community & Thematic Partner.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Sponsor a "Global Internet Hub" or "Smart Region" prize track. Provide 1-2 judges for that track (ideally experts in data center operations or network infrastructure). Help recruit mentors from their data center and infrastructure partners.
  - **Proposed "Give":** A tangible, innovative project (or set of projects) to feature on their "Virtual Innovation Spotlight". This provides branding as a key player in the "I-64 Innovation Corridor" and generates new "smart infrastructure" ideas for their portfolio.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** John W. Martin, President and CEO.
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - Their "Virtual Innovation Spotlight" webinar series is the precedent. The hackathon's "Demo Day" can be offered to them as a high-energy, *in-person* spotlight event to feature and record.

15. Partner Dossier: Metropolitan Business League (MBL)

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** Metropolitan Business League (MBL)
  - **Website:** thembl.org (inferred)
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
  - **Sector/Focus:** A key community organization focusing on the development of small, women-owned, and minority-owned (SWaM) businesses.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** The MBL is a central hub for Black and diverse entrepreneurs in Richmond. They are a formal partner with Capital One, helping to administer the "We Care RVA Recovery Grant Fund".
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** This is the hackathon's *key partner for inclusive entrepreneurship*. A "civic-tech" event that claims to serve the community *must* reflect the entire community. The MBL provides authentic engagement, outreach, and mentorship from diverse business leaders, ensuring the solutions built are equitable and accessible.
  - **History of Sponsorship:** The MBL partners with Capital One on grant-making and hosts its own "exclusive workshops, events, and networking opportunities" for its members.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Inclusive Entrepreneurship, SWaM Businesses, Community Wealth Building, Social Impact.

- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Community & Diversity Partner.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** Serve as the official "Inclusive Entrepreneurship Partner." Promote the hackathon to their network of SWaM businesses. Provide 3-5 mentors and judges from their membership to advise teams on building equitable business models. Help co-design a "Community Impact" prize.
  - **Proposed "Give":** Visibility for their members and their mission. A platform to connect their non-tech entrepreneurs with tech talent. Co-branding on a "Diversity in Tech" or "Equitable Impact" award. This partnership also provides a tangible "give" back to their partner, Capital One, by furthering their joint mission.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** The President/CEO of the MBL.
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - Their successful grant-making partnership with Capital One is the key leverage point. The hackathon can be pitched *with* Capital One as a joint initiative, fulfilling Capital One's stated goal of supporting MBL and the SWaM community.

V. Pillar 4: The Corporate & Tech Sponsors (Resources & Mentorship)

This pillar is the primary source of funding, high-skill mentors, infrastructure (e.g., cloud credits, APIs), and prizes. The engagement strategy is not to send generic "asks," but to present each corporation with a *custom-tailored justification* based on their *specific, publicly-stated CSR/ESG goals* and *urgent hiring needs*. This approach frames the hackathon not as a charitable donation, but as a high-ROI *solution* to their strategic objectives in talent acquisition (AWS, CoStar), community engagement (CapTech, Capital One), and applied innovation (Dominion Energy).

16. Partner Dossier: Capital One

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** Capital One
  - **Website:** capitalone.com
  - **HQ City:** Tysons, VA (with a massive corporate campus and strategic presence in Richmond).
  - **Sector/Focus:** Financial Services, FinTech.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** Capital One is the most deeply integrated corporate citizen in RVA's innovation ecosystem. They are the founding partner of the 1717 Innovation Center , a formal partner of VCU Engineering and VCU Brandcenter , a partner of Lighthouse Network , and the Board Chair for Startup Virginia.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** (See Top 5 Rationale). They are the central node. A successful hackathon *validates and reinforces their entire RVA innovation investment*. Their 2024 Annual Report and ESG goals are focused on "community engagement" and "advancing socioeconomic mobility."
  - **History of Sponsorship:** Their "Tech Pro Bono" program is a *direct precedent*, providing skilled tech associates to community-driven projects. They have awarded

over $3.5 million in grants in Richmond to partners like the MBL.
    - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** FinTech, Financial Literacy , AI, Data Analytics, Cybersecurity , Community Wealth Building (BIPOC Small Business Investment).
- **3. Engagement Model:**
    - **Possible Partnership Type:** Title & Strategic Sponsor.
    - **Proposed "Ask":** "Title Sponsor for the 'FinTech & Community Impact' Track" (or Title Sponsor for the entire event). A funding commitment of $25,000+. Provide 10-15 mentors and judges mobilized through their existing "Tech Pro Bono" program. A keynote speaker on "FinTech for Good."
    - **Proposed "Give":** A high-visibility flagship event that unites all their key RVA partners (VCU, SVA, MBL) under one roof. This provides direct access to top FinTech, AI, and Data talent and a "game-changer" pro bono opportunity for their associates. It is a direct, tangible fulfillment of their 2024-2025 ESG/CSR goals.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
    - **Ideal Contact:** Matt Briggs, VP of Product Management. (He is the *Board Chair* for Startup Virginia, providing a warm, ecosystem-focused introduction).
    - **Secondary Contact:** Melanie Frank, Managing VP, Cyber Security (for a cyber-focused track).
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
    - **Case Study:** Their "Tech Pro Bono" engagement with Partnership for the Future (PFF). In this project, Capital One associates cleaned 20 years of student data and built a cloud-based AI tool for the nonprofit. The hackathon can be pitched as a way to *scale this successful model* to 20+ nonprofits simultaneously over a single weekend.

17. Partner Dossier: Dominion Energy

- **1. Basic Profile:**
    - **Name:** Dominion Energy
    - **Website:** dominionenergy.com
    - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
    - **Sector/Focus:** Energy & Utilities.
    - **Connection to Innovation:** Major RVA employer and a pillar of the corporate community. They operate the Dominion Energy Innovation Center (DEIC) and the Dominion Energy Charitable Foundation.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
    - **Why this org aligns:** (See Top 5 Rationale). They have a *direct hackathon precedent*. Their Charitable Foundation grants ($1,000 - $15,000) are a *perfect match* for a mid-level sponsorship tier, making the ask realistic and easy to process.
    - **History of Sponsorship:** Co-hosted the "SPARK RVA" 24-hour innovation challenge with VCU da Vinci Center. Their foundation's 2024-2025 reports and grant programs show a deep commitment to STEM Education and Environmental Stewardship.
    - **Key Thematic Overlaps: Sustainability** (clear #1), Clean Energy, Environmental Stewardship , Smart Grid, Nuclear/Hydrogen (from SPARK RVA) , STEM Education (workforce development).
- **3. Engagement Model:**
    - **Possible Partnership Type:** Title & Infrastructure Sponsor.

    - **Proposed "Ask":** "Title Sponsor for the 'Clean Energy & Sustainability' Track" (funding of $15,000 - $25,000). Provide event power and utilities (in-kind). Provide 5-10 specialized mentors from the DEIC and their new technology teams (e.g., Small Modular Reactors (SMRs) or Renewable Natural Gas (RNG)).
    - **Proposed "Give":** A scaled-up, higher-impact version of their successful SPARK RVA event. This delivers a tangible, press-worthy "net-zero" community project. It directly fulfills their 2024-2025 CSR goals and supports their STEM pipeline.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
    - **Ideal Contact:** Braden Croy, Program Director at the DEIC.
    - **Secondary Contact:** Utibe Bassey, VP of Customer Experience (He sits on the Startup Virginia board, providing another "ecosystem" entry point).
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
    - **Case Study:** SPARK RVA. This is the entire pitch. It was a 24-hour, $8,500 prize pool event focused on energy tech. The first email to Braden Croy should reference this success and propose a "10x" version with more partners.

18. Partner Dossier: AWS (Amazon Web Services)

- **1. Basic Profile:**
    - **Name:** Amazon Web Services (AWS)
    - **Website:** aws.amazon.com
    - **HQ City:** Seattle, WA (with a massive and growing data center and operational presence in Northern Virginia and the Richmond region).
    - **Sector/Focus:** Cloud Computing, Infrastructure, AI.
    - **Connection to Innovation:** AWS is making a *$35 billion investment* in new data center campuses across Virginia by 2040, creating at least 1,000 new jobs.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
    - **Why this org aligns:** (See Top 5 Rationale). Their entire VA community strategy *is* workforce development. This $35B investment and 1,000+ new jobs creates an urgent, massive, and long-term need for a local tech talent pipeline. We are providing that pipeline.
    - **History of Sponsorship:** AWS runs numerous "AWS Skills Training Programs" and "AWS InCommunities" events in Virginia. They have a proven, successful partnership with Northern Virginia Community College (NOVA) and host events like "AWS Girls' Tech Day". Their stated goal is "empowering future builders through education".
    - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** Cloud Infrastructure, AI/Machine Learning, Data Analytics, "Smart City" Infrastructure, Digital Skills Training.
- **3. Engagement Model:**
    - **Possible Partnership Type:** Infrastructure & Talent Sponsor.
    - **Proposed "Ask":** "Official Infrastructure Sponsor" (provide AWS credits for all participating teams). "Talent Pipeline Sponsor" (funding of $15,000+). Provide 5-10 "Solutions Architect" mentors and judges. An "AWS Prize for Best Cloud Architecture."
    - **Proposed "Give":** Direct, curated, high-speed access to hundreds of RVA's top developers (their future 1,000+ employees). This engagement offers them a *new* academic partner (Reynolds Community College) to mirror their NOVA success. It also provides a high-visibility PR story about their $35B investment *already*

benefiting the RVA community.

- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** AWS Virginia Operations Leader (Jeff McCormick was mentioned in a 2025 article) or the regional Community Engagement Manager (Wilberte Paul was mentioned for Girls' Tech Day).
  - **Secondary Contact:** Lindsay Winter, Head of Virginia Public Policy. (She is the Co-Chair of the VA Chamber of Commerce's *Innovation and Technology Industry Council* and a key state-level contact).
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
  - **Case Study:** Their partnership with Northern Virginia Community College (NOVA) and their "AWS Fiber Optic Fusion Splicing Certificate Course". This shows a clear, replicable model of partnering with local Virginia academic institutions on workforce development. The hackathon offers them the *entire* RVA academic ecosystem (VCU, UR, Reynolds) in a single, high-impact event.

19. Partner Dossier: CapTech

- **1. Basic Profile:**
  - **Name:** CapTech
  - **Website:** captechconsulting.com
  - **HQ City:** Richmond, VA
  - **Sector/Focus:** Technology Consulting.
  - **Connection to Innovation:** A major RVA tech employer and thought leader. CapTech is a formal "Recruitment Partner" of VCU Engineering and a Principal sits on the Board of Directors for Startup Virginia.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
  - **Why this org aligns:** This is a *values-aligned* partner. Their 2024 Impact Report and "CapTech Cares" program are a *perfect match* for a civic-tech hackathon. Their corporate belief statement is, "We are committed to leveraging our resources and strengths as innovators, engineers, and strategists to improve the lives of underrepresented and disadvantaged people in the communities we serve".
  - **History of Sponsorship:** Their Diversity, Inclusion, & Belonging (DIB) Council has a "Community Impact" committee focused on "Supporting underrepresented groups within STEM". Their 2024 Impact Report *names* "Making Technology Accessible and Available" as a key program focus area. They also have a precedent of local "tech for good" pro bono work, such as their project for Diversity Richmond.
  - **Key Thematic Overlaps:** STEM Education, Diversity in Tech (DIB) , Digital Accessibility , AI (Generative AI, AI Cloud Agents).
- **3. Engagement Model:**
  - **Possible Partnership Type:** Pillar & Mentorship Sponsor.
  - **Proposed "Ask":** "Title Sponsor for the 'DEI & Accessibility in Tech' Track" (funding of $10,000 - $15,000). Provide 10-15 consultant mentors (their "innovators, engineers and strategists"). A judge from their DIB Council.
  - **Proposed "Give":** A *direct, tangible fulfillment* of their 2024 Impact Report goals. This event is a pre-packaged story they can feature *in their 2025 Impact Report*. It provides direct access to diverse, high-potential talent that fits their culture.
- **4. Contact Targets:**
  - **Ideal Contact:** Tom Krieger, Principal. (He sits on the Startup Virginia board,

providing a warm "ecosystem" introduction).
    - **Secondary Contact:** The internal lead for the "Community Impact" DIB Committee.
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
    - Their pro bono project for Diversity Richmond is a clear precedent for local, tech-for-good community engagement in RVA. The hackathon is an opportunity to do this at scale.

20. Partner Dossier: CoStar Group

- **1. Basic Profile:**
    - **Name:** CoStar Group
    - **Website:** costargroup.com
    - **HQ City:** Washington, D.C. (with a major corporate campus in Richmond).
    - **Sector/Focus:** Commercial Real Estate Information, Analytics, and Data Marketplaces.
    - **Connection to Innovation:** CoStar is one of Richmond's largest private employers. They are currently undergoing a massive *$460M+ corporate campus expansion* in RVA, which is set to create *2,000 new jobs*.
- **2. Alignment Potential:**
    - **Why this org aligns:** This is a *talent acquisition* partner, pure and simple. They have an immediate and massive need for 2,000 new *tech-focused* employees, including roles in "software development, customer service, and support functions". The hackathon is a direct delivery mechanism for that talent pipeline.
    - **History of Sponsorship:** Their RVA expansion plan *explicitly states* that the new campus "will leverage partnerships with higher education institutions in Virginia to help drive success". They are already a formal partner of VCU Engineering.
    - **Key Thematic Overlaps: Data Analytics** (their core business), Real Estate Tech ("PropTech"), AI/Data Science , **Sustainability** (their new $460M RVA campus is being built to "LEED Net Zero" and "WELL Platinum" certifications).
- **3. Engagement Model:**
    - **Possible Partnership Type:** Talent & Prize Sponsor.
    - **Proposed "Ask":** "Title Sponsor for the 'Data & AI' or 'Smart Real Estate' Track" (funding of $15,000 - $20,000). Provide 5-10 data scientist and software developer mentors/judges. Provide a "PropTech" or real estate dataset for the challenge. A "CoStar Prize" of "Guaranteed Interviews for CoStar's 2025 Internship Program."
    - **Proposed "Give":** Direct, curated access to Richmond's top data science and software engineering students (their 2,000 future hires). This event provides a high-visibility *execution* of their publicly stated goal to "leverage partnerships with higher education".
- **4. Contact Targets:**
    - **Ideal Contact:** The University Relations Lead for the Richmond campus (the person responsible for enacting the "higher education partnerships").
    - **Secondary Contact:** Mike McLaurin, Director, Global Cyber Security.
- **5. Case Studies / Precedent:**
    - Their existing partnership with VCU Engineering is the established precedent. Their 2024 ESG Report and its focus on the sustainable new RVA campus provides the *thematic justification* for a "PropTech & Sustainability" track.

VI. Strategic & Tactical Insights for Partnership Execution

This section provides an actionable playbook for the hackathon's partnership and outreach team. It synthesizes case studies, benchmark data, and CSR reports into a "how-to" guide for securing and structuring the alliances detailed above.

A. Partnership Model Analysis: The "Triangle" Approach

The most successful and sustainable civic-tech partnerships are "triangles" that link University (talent), Corporate (resources), and Community (problems/legitimacy) interests. A standalone hackathon struggles for resources and relevance; an event embedded within the existing ecosystem thrives.

- **Case Study 1: The BU/Howard Civic Tech Hackathon (National Model)**
    - **Analysis:** This event, which grew to 190 students from 19 schools, demonstrates the power of this "triangle" model.
    - **University:** Boston University + Howard University (an HBCU). This academic partnership immediately baked in a strong DEI and cross-institutional component.
    - **Corporate:** Sponsored by Bose, Accenture, MassMutual, and SharkNinja. This provided $7,000+ in prizes and, more importantly, high-skill industry mentors.
    - **Community:** The keynote was delivered by the Boston City Council President. This provided high-level municipal validation and helped ground the event's "tracks" (Social Justice, Economic Empowerment, Sustainability) in real-world civic issues.
    - **Our Playbook:** This model is perfectly replicable in Richmond: **VCU/UR/Reynolds (University)** + **Capital One/AWS/Dominion (Corporate)** + **City of Richmond/MBL (Community)**.
- **Case Study 2: The SPARK RVA Innovation Challenge (Local Model)**
    - **Analysis:** This 24-hour event, hosted in February, is the most powerful local precedent.
    - **University:** VCU da Vinci Center served as the academic host, providing the venue and programmatic expertise.
    - **Corporate:** The Dominion Energy Innovation Center (DEIC) was the title sponsor, providing the thematic focus (nuclear/hydrogen energy) and the $8,500 prize pool.
    - **Our Playbook:** This is the *proven local model*. The strategy is to take this successful two-partner model (VCU + Dominion) and *add the third (Community)* leg of the triangle (City of Richmond) while scaling the corporate pillar (adding AWS, Capital One, etc.). The pitch to VCU and Dominion is not "let's invent something new," but "let's scale your SPARK RVA success."

B. Benchmark Sponsorship Tiers & Deliverables

A clear, tiered prospectus is essential. It allows partners to self-select a level that matches their budget and strategic goals (e.g., Talent Acquisition vs. Brand Awareness). The following structure is based on benchmarks from comparable tech and civic hackathon events.

Table 2: Proposed RVA Civic-Tech Hackathon Sponsorship Tiers

Tier Level	Price Range	Target Audience	Proposed "Ask" (Cash + In-Kind)	Proposed "Give" (Key Benefits)
Tier 1: Community Partner	$1,000 - $2,500	Local tech companies, startups (e.g., from SVA), community groups (RVA Works).	$1,500 + 2 mentors	Logo on event website; Mention in program; Access to talent database; 2 mentor/judge slots.
Tier 2: Innovator Partner	$5,000 - $10,000	Mid-size tech firms, VCs, specialized entities (e.g., CapTech, Activation Capital, VIPC).	$7,500 + "Best in..." Prize	All Tier 1 benefits + Host a 1-hr skills workshop; Dedicated branding on a specific prize (e.g., "Best HealthTech Solution"); 2 seats on prize judging panel.
Tier 3: Pillar Sponsor	$15,000 - $25,000	Major corporations with specific thematic goals (e.g., Dominion, CoStar, AWS).	$20,000 + 10 mentors + API/Data access	All Tier 2 benefits + "Title Sponsor" of a full thematic track (e.g., "The Dominion Energy Sustainability Track"); 5-min keynote to track participants; Targeted recruitment session.
Tier 4: Title Sponsor	$30,000+	One keystone, "Top 5" partner (e.g., Capital One).	$35,000 + 15 mentors	All Tier 3 benefits + "Presented by [Partner]" on all event media; Opening ceremony keynote; "Presented by" in all press releases; A custom-designed challenge track.

C. Leveraging CSR & ESG Mandates: The "Justification Toolkit"

The outreach must *never* lead with a generic "ask for money." The pitch must be a *solution* to the partner's publicly stated strategic goals. This provides the internal champion with the *exact*

language and justification needed to secure internal approval.

Table 3: CSR/ESG Justification Matrix for Corporate Outreach

Partner	CSR/ESG Report / Stated Goal	Verbatim Quote / Data Point	The "Solution" Pitch
Capital One	2024 ESG Report & "Tech Pro Bono" Program	Goal: "Enacting change by creating economic opportunity in our communities". Precedent: "game-changer" AI tool for PFF.	"We offer a 'Tech Pro Bono' model *at scale*, directly 'creating economic opportunity' by building tech solutions for 20+ RVA nonprofits, scaling the impact of your PFF success."
Dominion Energy	2024-2025 Sustainability & CSR Reports	Goal 1: "Education... especially in STEM and energy fields". Goal 2: "Environmental Stewardship". "Net-zero by 2050".	"We provide a direct 'STEM Education' pipeline and will host a dedicated track for your 'Net-zero' goals, scaling your successful SPARK RVA model to a larger audience."
CapTech	2024 Impact Report & "CapTech Cares" Program	Goal 1: "Making Technology Accessible and Available". Goal 2: "Supporting underrepresented groups within STEM".	"This event is a direct fulfillment of your 2024 Impact Report. We request you sponsor the 'Accessibility & DEI in Tech' track, 100% aligned with your 'CapTech Cares' mission."
CoStar Group	2024 ESG Report & RVA Expansion Plan	Goal 1: "$460M+ expansion... 2,000 new jobs". Goal 2: "leverage partnerships with higher education institutions in Virginia".	"We are your 'higher education partnership' solution, delivering hundreds of data scientists and software developers (your 2,000 future hires) from VCU, UR, and Reynolds to your recruiting team."
AWS	VA Community Engagement Strategy	Goal: "$35 billion... investment... 1,000 new jobs". Strategy: "empowering future builders through education" , e.g., NOVA	"We are your RVA-based workforce development engine. We deliver the 'future builders' you need for your $35B expansion,

Partner	CSR/ESG Report / Stated Goal	Verbatim Quote / Data Point	The "Solution" Pitch
		partnership.	connecting you to VCU, UR, and Reynolds in one weekend."

D. Media & Amplification Contact List

A proactive media strategy is essential for maximizing sponsor value and community reach. The outreach should be two-pronged: (1) The *business/economic impact* angle for business publications, and (2) The *community/innovation* angle for tech-focused outlets.

Table 4: Target Media Contact List & Pitch Angles

Outlet	Key Contacts	Pitch Angle & Narrative
Richmond BizSense	**Michael Schwartz, Editor** (michael@richmondbizsense.com) **Jonathan Spiers, Sr. Reporter** (jonathan@richmondbizsense.com)	**The Economic/Jobs Angle:** "RVA's Tech Giants (Capital One, CoStar, AWS) and Top Universities (VCU, UR) Team Up for Major Civic-Tech Hackathon; Driving Talent for RVA's 3,000+ Open Tech Jobs."
RVA Tech	**Nick Serfass, CEO** (info@rvatech.com) **Zak Brown, RVA Data Science Lead**	**The Community Angle:** "The RVA Tech Community Unites to Launch RVA's Largest-Ever Civic-Tech Hackathon, Connecting Developers (RVA.js), Data Scientists (RVA Data Hackers), and Nonprofits."
Virginia Public Media (VPM) / Radio IQ	**Pamela D'Angelo, Producer** (pamelaadangelo@gmail.com)	**The Human-Impact Angle:** "More than Code: RVA's Top Tech Talent Spends 48 Hours Building Solutions for Local Nonprofits Addressing Homelessness, Food Access, and Equity." (Focus on U of R's Bonner CCE).
6AM City (RICtoday)	General Submission / Staff	**The "What-to-Do" Angle:** "Richmond's innovation scene is buzzing. Here's how you can get involved in the massive RVA Civic-Tech Hackathon this fall." (Focus on the energy, students, and visual "Demo Day").

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